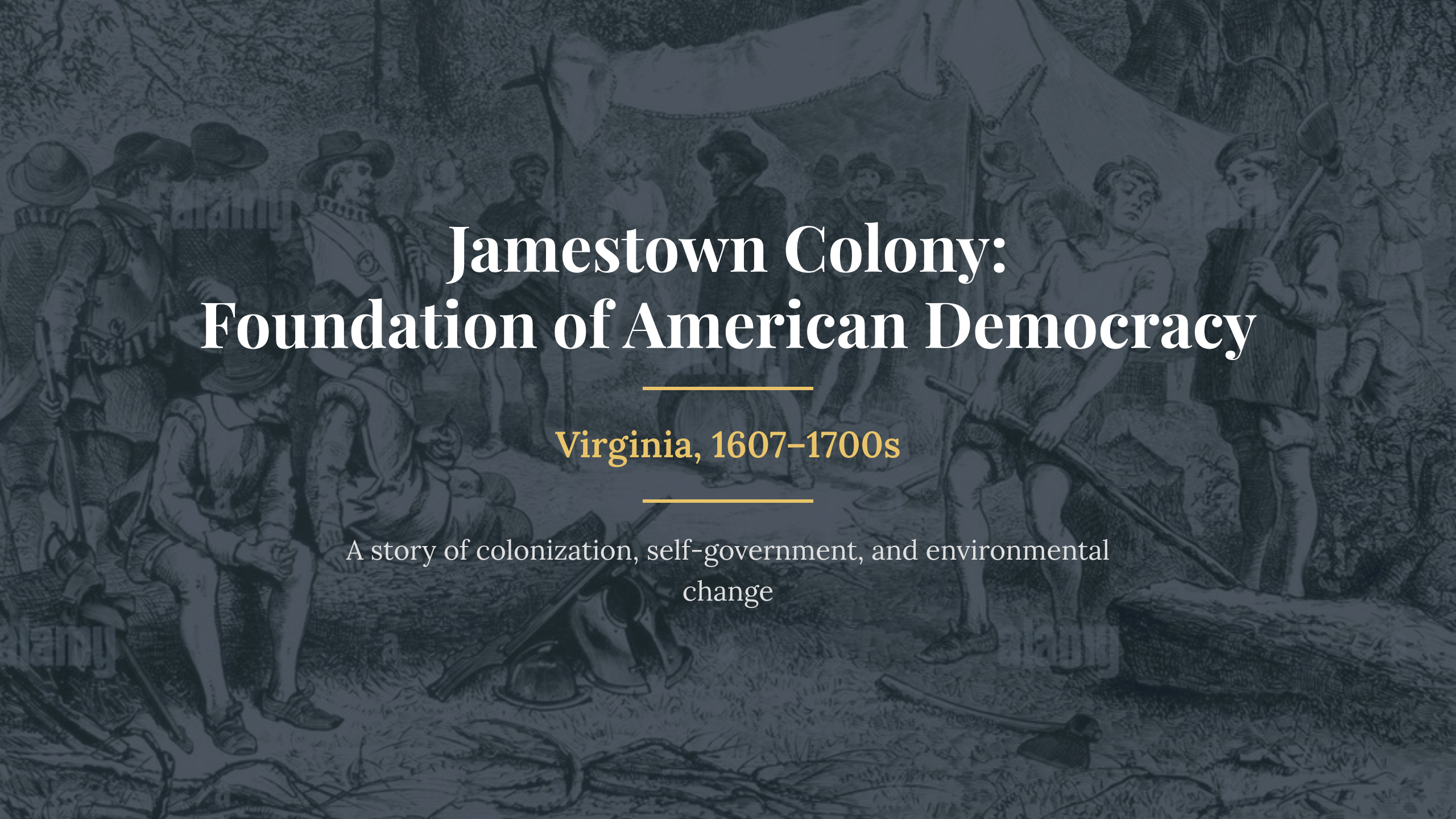


Jamestown Colony: Foundation of American Democracy

Virginia, 1607–1700s

A story of colonization, self-government, and environmental change

Lesson Objectives

- **Identify** the reasons for English colonization.
- **Explain** how Virginia began a tradition of representative government.
- **Describe** how different groups in Jamestown interacted with the environment.

Why Did the English Colonize?

- **Economic opportunity:** profit for investors (Virginia Company) and settlers.
- **Competition with Spain and France;** expand English power and influence.
- **Search for wealth** (gold/silver) and new resources (tobacco, timber).
- **New markets** and hoped-for routes to Asia.
- **Land and social mobility** for commoners at home.

Founding Jamestown, 1607

Reconstruction of James Fort at Jamestown

- **104 settlers** established Jamestown on a tidal island 60 miles up the James River.
- **Site chosen** for deep water and defense; within Powhatan homelands.
- **Built a triangular fort;** provided protection against potential attacks.
- **Early survival** relied on trade with Powhatan peoples.

Early Challenges and Harsh Conditions

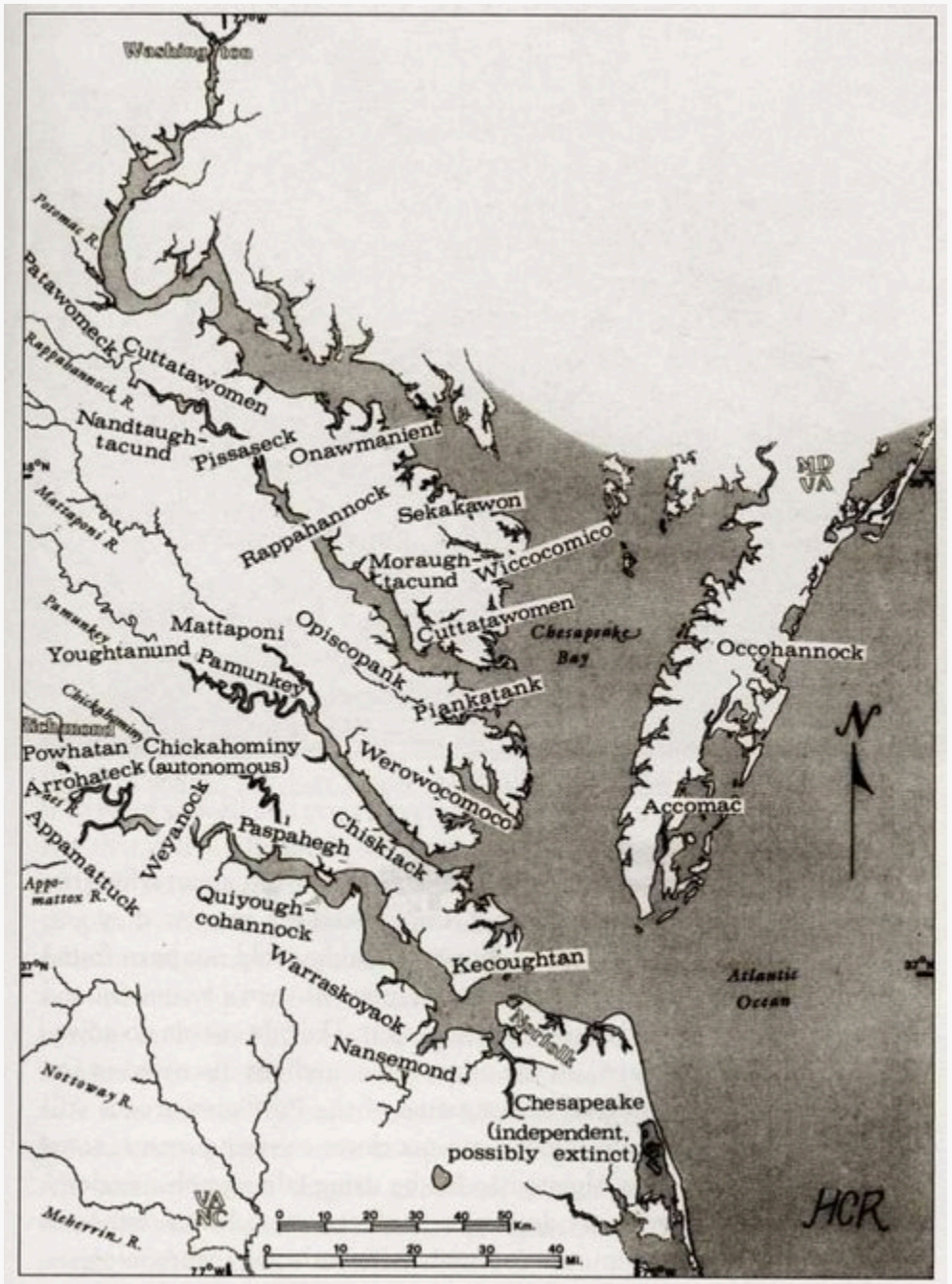


Fig. 3.1. Map of the Powhatan paramount chiefdom in 1607. Courtesy of Helen C. Rountree.

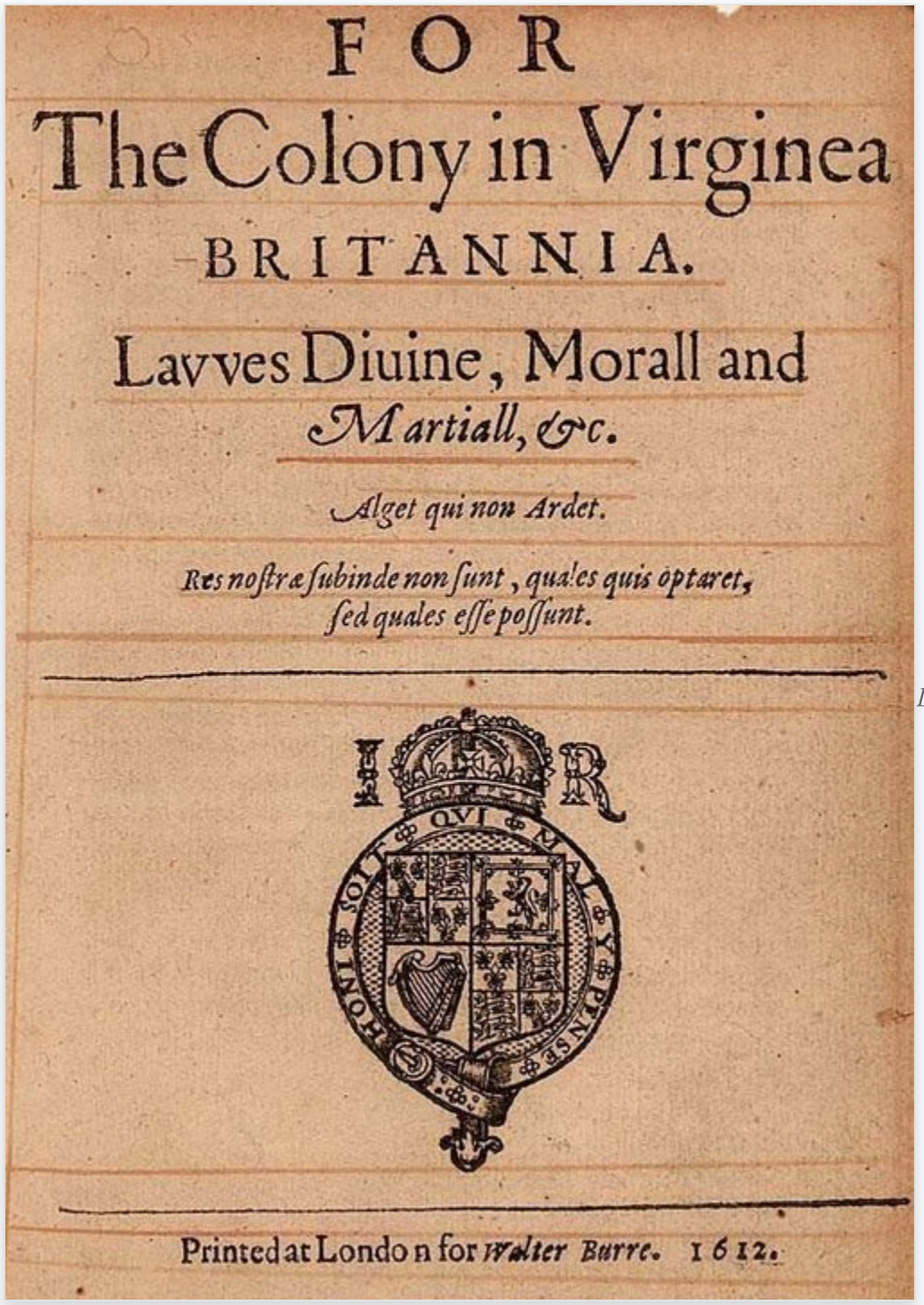
- **Swampy site, brackish water, mosquitoes** → disease.
- **Food shortages and limited farming skills** → starvation risk.
- **Periodic conflict** disrupted trade with Powhatan neighbors.
- The **Starving Time (1609–1610)** tested the colony's survival.

A Military-Style Regime

> *"No Man will go... to have less freedom there than here."*
>
> — *John Smith, after his return to England*

- **Work regulated by drumbeat;** tasks strictly assigned.
- Governors ran the colony **like a military outpost.**
- **Harsh laws:** even stealing an ear of corn could mean death.
- **Result:** a system unlikely to attract new settlers.

Reforms of 1619


FOR
The Colony in Virginea
BRITANNIA.
Lavves Diuine, Morall and
Martiall, &c.
Alget qui non Ardet.
Res noſtræ ſubinde non ſunt, quales quis optaret,
ſed quales eſſe poſſunt.
IOHANNES ✠ SOLT ✠ MAL ✠ YPRINSE ✠
Printed at Londo n for Walter Burre. 1612.

Virginia Company Charter Document, 1619

- **Virginia Company** ordered a new, more consultative government.
- **Male settlers** could elect burgesses (representatives).
- **Shared lawmaking** between governor, his council, and elected burgesses.

The House of Burgesses

First Virginia Colonial Assembly, 1619

- **First met July–August 1619** in Jamestown's church.
- **First representative assembly** in English North America.
- **English roots:** Magna Carta (1215), Parliament, rule of law.
- **Voting evolved:** initially broad (no property requirement); by 1670 restricted to free white male property owners.
- Colonists called the 1619 frame their **"Great Charter."**

Women in Jamestown (1608–1619)

Women in colonial Jamestown faced harsh conditions and daily struggles

- **First arrivals in 1608:** Mistress Forrest and her maid, Anne Burras.
- **1619:** Virginia Company sent ~100 women to "make the men more settled."
- **Marriage cost:** 150 pounds of tobacco paid to the Virginia Company.
- **Daily roles:** Making food, clothing, and medicines; many died young from hard work or childbirth.
- **By 1624:** Fewer than 300 women compared to over 1,000 men.

Growth and a Tobacco Economy

- **Tobacco** became the cash crop driving Virginia's expansion and economy.
- **Wealthy planters** controlled the best lands along the tidewater region.
- **Indentured servants**, after completing their period of service, sought farmland of their own.
- As coastal lands were claimed, settlers pushed the **frontier inland**, encroaching on Native American territories.

People and the Environment

- **English** selected a defensible but unhealthy site; altered waterways and soils.
- **Forests** were cleared; large tobacco fields transformed the landscape.
- **Africans** brought agricultural skills; their labor accelerated land conversion.
- **Powhatan** lands and food systems were disrupted; trade gave way to conflict.
- **Frontier expansion** intensified competition for land and resources.

Africans in Virginia and Labor Systems

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- **Early presence:** Before 1619, at least 15 Black men and 17 Black women already lived in Virginia.
- **1619 arrival:** Dutch ship brought ~20 Africans who were sold to Virginians and valued for their agricultural skills.
- **Varied status:** Some were enslaved for life; others were indentured servants. Anthony Johnson became a free planter owning 250 acres and employing 5 servants.
- **After Bacon's Rebellion (1676):** Laws hardened lifelong, hereditary slavery; free Africans lost rights, including voting rights by early 1700s.

Legacy and Significance

- **House of Burgesses** seeded American representative government.
- Settlers embraced the idea they should have a **say in colonial affairs**.
- **Tobacco** tied Virginia to Atlantic markets and created labor demands.
- Expansion **dispossessed Native peoples** and reshaped ecosystems.
- **Racial slavery** became foundational to society and politics.

Conclusion

- **Reasons for English colonization:** profit, power, and opportunity for both investors and settlers.
- **Representative government:** House of Burgesses (1619) rooted in English legal tradition.
- **Environmental interactions:** English, Powhatan, and Africans transformed Virginia's landscape through agriculture and settlement.
- **Key dates:** **1607** Settlement, **1619** Burgesses & Africans arrive, **1670** Voting restrictions, **1676** Bacon's Rebellion.
- **Big idea:** Jamestown linked governance, economy, and environment—with lasting impact on American development.